make less noise. If this means throwing myself on to the wooden floor for a diving serve and volley, landing face down and then springing back to respond when Lendl's return shimmies off the net in the final serve-breaking game, I do so without hesitation. There is no wall, no alley, no room that cannot be turned into a sporting arena, nowhere that I am unable to daydream what it must be like to be Boris Becker. He is my first superhero, his supernatural status confirmed to me when the lad next door insisted on playing Spider-Man and Batman around the outside of the houses and ended up flying through the glass of the front porch. I looked at him, splayed out in the mess, face up in his Spider-Man costume, and decided Boris was a better bet.

Sport is the only thing that ever holds my attention, the only thing that I want to be doing. Nothing else comes remotely close. My mum's earliest memories of me sitting still are in front of the snooker, watching a black-and-white TV that my grandad had. It transfixes me. It's like a puzzle to solve, but one I somehow understand the principles of and rules to without needing them explained. I am not just looking at it, I can *see* it. I can see things before they happen; pitfalls and traps and sequences play out in front of me and I can remember them very quickly, scoop up all the information without any excess thought. There's one player – there's always one specifically from each sport – that I feel closely affiliated with. Steve Davis is assured and omnipotent, ruling the landscape of snooker on TV. He, like Becker, has some sort of tangible connection to the sport he plays. The game somehow *is* him. Every time he plays, the world is airbrushed with an unfussiness and a simplicity that evades me in my life. He also has a look on his face – an acquired, knowing humour, a dry wit. It's like he's having a conversation with himself, making a joke that only he has heard. I like that about him. My cousin and I play snooker on the half-sized table at my grandparents', where I practise that knowing look, the smirk that lurks behind the seriousness of it all, while wandering around the table with deadly purpose.

Even before Boris Becker introduced me to high-risk indoor re-enactment or Steve Davis taught me layered and unreachable knowing, I was being channelled into sport. At Christmas, my uncle would take me upstairs at my grandparents' and set the dartboard up on the floor, when I was still barely able to walk, ensuring I could get eyeline with it, propped